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QUEBEC & LEGAL

COLLECTION

Buying or Selling in Winter

Myths and realities of winter real estate in Quebec.



2026 EDITION

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Important notice

This guide is provided for informational and educational purposes only. It presents general information about real estate in Quebec and does not constitute personalized real estate, legal, tax or financial advice. Every real estate situation is different, and you should consult the appropriate professionals before making a decision about a transaction.

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Buying or Selling in Winter

Myths and realities of winter real estate in Quebec

“You should not sell in winter. " Really ? In Quebec, winter has its particularities - snow, cold, short days - but it also offers real opportunities, for buying and selling. This guide separates myth from reality, season by season.

You will see why winter buyers are often the most serious, how to present a property when everything is white, what advantages winter gives to the buyer, and how to manage the practical aspects specific to the Quebec climate (snow removal, inspection in the snow, moving in -20°C).

Each chapter ends with concrete advice. At the end, an action plan, a glossary and a quiz to anchor the essentials.

The benchmarks in this guide apply to Greater Montreal: adapt them to your sector and always validate your strategy with your broker according to market conditions at the time of action.

CHAPTER

The myth of the “bad season”

> *Nuance a stubborn preconceived idea.*

There are generally fewer properties for sale and fewer buyers in winter. But “less numerous” does not mean “bad”: it is often even the opposite for those who know how to read the market.

Buyers who visit in January at -15°C are not Sunday tourists: they have a real need (transfer, separation, family expansion, end of lease) and a tight deadline. Opposite, fewer sellers are posting, so your property suffers **less direct competition** than at the height of spring.

What the season really changes:

- **Volume** : fewer registrations and fewer active buyers.
- **Motivation** : the buyers present are more determined.
- **Competition** : fewer comparable properties displayed at the same time as yours.
- **Deadlines** : sometimes a little longer, but with firmer offers.

Result: a good property, well prepared and above all **good price**, can sell very well in winter - sometimes faster than an overvalued property drowned in spring supply.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Don’t postpone a sale just “because it’s winter.” A buyer who travels in the middle of a storm is a motivated buyer. Fewer visitors, but a much better level of seriousness: this is often a winning compromise for the seller.*

CHAPTER

Selling in winter: presenting yourself well

> *Compensate for the challenges of the season, point by point.*

Winter requires some presentation adjustments, all of which are easy to master once you think about it. The goal: for the buyer to forget about the cold as soon as they walk through the door.

Outside, the first impression is made before even entering:

- Clear snow and ice from the entrance, steps and sidewalk before each visit - it's a matter of welcome *and* safety (responsibility).
- Clear the address plaque, the steps and access to the shed or garage.
- Provide an absorbent mat and a space for boots at the entrance.

Inside, we sell comfort and warmth:

- Maximize light (short days): curtains open, all lamps on, warm light bulbs.
- Heat to a welcoming temperature during visits.
- Highlight energy efficiency: recent windows, insulation, heat pump, fireplace.

Finally, compensate for the absence of greenery: add some **summer photos** of the land, yard and landscaping, so that the buyer sees the full potential of the property.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *In winter, sell a sensation: a house that is warm, bright and easy to access despite the snow. And always show what the terrain looks like in summer - that's what the buyer can't imagine under 40 cm of snow.*

CHAPTER

Buying in winter: opportunities

> *Take advantage of the advantages on the buyer's side.*

For the buyer, winter is often the best season - as long as you know how to look. Two advantages combine: less competition and an inspection “in extreme conditions”.

Less competition, more power. With few active buyers, bidding wars are rarer and the sellers present are often in a hurry (moving already planned, property already unoccupied, double mortgage to avoid). Your room for negotiation is widened.

The house shows itself in its true light. The cold reveals what summer hides. Take advantage of the visit to observe:

- Drafts at windows and doors, feeling of “cold wall”.
- Heating efficiency and noise; ask them **actual costs** of the last 12 months.
- Presence of ice on the ground, ice dams on the roof or abundant icicles (a sign of poor insulation or attic ventilation).
- Quality of snow removal and access; behavior of the sloping entrance.

This allows you to test the property under its most demanding conditions - an inspection advantage the summer buyer will never have.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Buying in winter means seeing the house in its worst light: drafts, ice, the real heating bill. What you see in January won't surprise you the following winter - and it gives you concrete arguments to negotiate.*

CHAPTER

Each season has its logic

> *Choose the moment according to your priorities, not according to prejudices.*

Rather than “good” or “bad” season, reason in compromise. Each period has its strengths and weaknesses, for both the buyer and the seller.

- **Spring** : the most active market. Lots of choice and buyers, open land - but strong competition and frequent bidding wars.
- **Summer** : strong market, exteriors and swimming pools to their advantage; slowdown during construction holidays.
- **Autumn** : serious buyers who want to settle in before winter; short window before slowdown.
- **Winter** : less volume, but reduced competition and very motivated buyers.

The “best” time therefore depends on your objective: **maximize the number of buyers** (spring), **reduce competition** (winter), or simply **track your life calendar** (transfer, birth, retirement). A seller who wants little competition and a buyer who wants to negotiate can both very well find what they want in January.

In all cases, the price and the preparation weigh much more than the season. A fair priced and impeccable property sells in all seasons; an overvalued property lingers even in the spring.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Don't let the calendar decide for you. The real question is not “is it the right season?” » but “is this the right time for me, and is my price fair?” ". These two answers matter much more than the weather.*

CHAPTER

Practical aspects of Quebec winter

> *Anticipate climate-specific logistics.*

In Quebec, winter adds concrete realities to the transaction. Well anticipated, they become simple organization rather than unpleasant surprises.

Inspection. Snow can hide the roof, the slope of the land, the drainage, the crack in a slab or the condition of the coating. Ask the seller for summer photos, note these points during the inspection and, if necessary, plan an additional check after the thaw.

Moving. Icy roads, short days and subzero temperatures complicate logistics:

- Book early: good movers are becoming rarer and July 1st is not the only possible date.
- Protect floors and furniture from calcium and humidity (carpets, reinforced cardboard).
- Keep a margin in the schedule in the event of a storm.

Taking possession. As soon as you hand over the keys, check that the heating is working, that the water has not been cut off (risk of freezing pipes in a vacant accommodation) and that the access is cleared of snow. Finally, make sure that your **home insurance is in effect** before the cold weather, including for a temporarily unoccupied property.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *You don't buy what you can't see. If snow obscures the roof and grounds, request summer photos and have it listed for inspection. And for any home left empty in winter: heating maintained and water monitored, otherwise a frozen pipe can cost a fortune.*

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

> *Your next steps, concretely.*

This week

1. Decide on my strategy without seasonal bias.
2. List winter adjustments (snow removal, lighting).

Within 30 days

1. Prepare a warm and accessible presentation.
2. Take advantage of a less crowded market.

Then

1. Act according to my needs, not according to the schedule.

Depending on the season

1. Adapt my presentation (snow removal, light, heat) if I sell in winter.
2. Take advantage of reduced competition and test the house in extreme cold if I buy in winter.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- Seasonality: variation in market activity depending on the season.
- Motivated buyers: those who visit in winter, often more serious.
- Winter curb appeal: snow-cleared access and warm presentation.
- Winter test: observe insulation, heating and infiltration in very cold weather.
- Competition from sellers: weaker in winter.

- Seasonality: variation in market activity depending on the season.
- Motivated buyers: those who visit in winter, often more serious.
- Winter curb appeal: snow-cleared access and warm presentation.
- Winter test: observe insulation, heating and infiltration in very cold weather.

- Ice dam: accumulation of ice at the edge of the roof, sign of insulation/ventilation to be checked.
- Winter possession: check heating, water and access upon handing over the keys.

GO FURTHER

Quiz - test yourself

1. In winter, there are generally:

A) More properties and buyers
B) Fewer of both, but more motivated buyers
C) No transactions
D) Zero prices

2. An advantage of selling in winter is:

A) More competition
B) Less competition between sellers
C) No buyer
D) Higher taxes

3. To sell well in winter, you must:

A) Leave the ice
B) Clear snow, maximize light and heat
C) Turn off the heating
D) Close the curtains

4. To compensate for short days, we should:

A) Lower the blinds
B) Maximize light (open curtains, warm lighting)
C) Visit at night
D) Change nothing

5. Buying in winter allows you to see:

A) The flowering garden
B) The behavior of the house in extreme cold
C) Nothing
D) The open swimming pool

6. Winter buyers are often:

A) Simple curious people
B) More motivated and serious
C) Non-existent
D) Tourists

7. The “best” time to trade:

A) Is always spring
B) Depends on your priorities and situation
C) Never exists
D) Is fixed by law

8. Spring is characterized by:

A) No buyer
B) Lots of choice but strong competition
C) Zero prices
D) No ownership

9. If the snow hides the roof from the visit, you must:

A) Ignore
B) Request summer photos and note it at inspection
C) Buy with your eyes closed
D) Cancel the purchase

10. A winter move requires above all:

A) No preparation
B) To provide margin (roads, ice, delays)
C) To move at night
D) To wait until summer

Answers

1. B - Fewer, more serious (chap. 1).
2. B - Reduced competition (chap. 1).
3. B - Comfort and access (chap. 2).
4. B - Maximize light (chap. 2).
5. B - Test under demanding conditions (chap. 3).
6. B - Stronger motivation (chaps. 1 and 3).
7. B - Each season has its logic (chap. 4).
8. B - High volume and competition (chap. 4).
9. B - Documenting what we don’t see (chap. 5).
10. B - Anticipate logistics (chap. 5).

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You now have the right keys in hand.

Every real estate journey is different.

If you would like to go further,
I would be happy to discuss
your project with you.



Make informed decisions.
Choose with confidence.
Live without regrets.

See you soon,
Emilie 🙂

Emilie Cauvier

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